

swear by the Crock-Pot® method of stripping hardware, which involves letting painted metal hardware cook overnight in a bath of water. (Just keep a separate cooker on hand for these non-food tasks.)

Purchase tip: When it comes to slow-cookers, most any brand will do. I have had great success from the small cookers sold at the Black Friday sales at popular retailers for a bargain. They work well for side dishes and small cuts of meat. If you plan on buying secondhand, be on the lookout for chips in the crock, discoloration on the interior of the cooking surface, and frayed electrical cords. These are signs of future problems, so stay away! Flea markets and garage sales are great places to find older but functioning slow-cookers for a fraction of the new price. I own several!

3. The veggie / rice steamer

I had this sitting in my cupboard for years after our wedding. I just didn't know how handy it could be. Now that I've had a chance to really try this puppy out, we are inseparable! What's not to like? It cooks veggies, meats, and rice without any stirring or tending. It uses much less electricity than a stovetop, and for those of us who are a bit rice-impaired (translation: sticky-rice bandits), it's an easy

way to impress guests. (Plus it's a really healthy way to eat.)

Forgo the bells and whistles. Rice and veggie steamers have come a long way. Too bad much of the "extras" are pointlessly expensive. I've never used the "flavor infuser" on my steamer. If the thing can steam veggies and cook rice, you're golden. Pay less by getting just what you'll be sure to need.

Follow the directions. This is a no-brainer that I'm surprised I couldn't figure out on my own. Only add water to the steam well. Be super careful when removing the lid. If you follow the basic instructions, you'll have awesome, tender veggies and extra-fluffy rice. (If you don't, you'll look like an idiot in front of your spouse and will be nursing a scalded wrist for a week.)

Use the recipe book. Each new steamer comes with a few recipes to get you started. Yes, they are simple, but they make an excellent jumping-off point for more daring meals.

Purchase tip: These also come up at used outlets fairly often. To be sure you really are getting a good deal, make sure the heating element works *before* you buy. (If this means you may have to add some water from the store sink and plug it in, do so.) Also, you will need to be sure you have the basic heating component, a drip pan, rice tray, veggie steamer basket, and a